"We failed to read the public mood"

Rupesh, aka Satish—central committee member of the main Naxal group, CPI (Maoist), head of the north sub zone of the Dandakaranya special zonal committee (DKSZC) and its chief ideologue—surrendered on October 17 with 209 armed cadres. The lean, Telugu-speaking Rupesh, and DKSZC member **Baji Rao** spoke to Senior Editor RAHUL NORONHA in Jagdalpur's 'Alcatraz', which houses high-value surrenderers, on laying down arms, misreading public mood, the movement's future and electoral politics. Edited excerpts of the interview:



LEAVING THE SHADOWS
Rupesh (seated) with Baji Rao (behind him in blue) and other cadres after their surrender at Jagdalpur, Chhattisgarh, Nov. 27

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Q. The past two years have seen a clear capitulation, coinciding with a shift in strategy by security forces. What weakened the Maoist movement?

Rupesh: We could not adopt the right strategy, nor could we reach all sections of society. For example, during the farmers' protest, we couldn't do much; the problems of farmers and labourers continue. Labour is upset, but our movement is not present among them, or among students or urban people. We were restricted to the tribal belt, even there not entirely. If a large number of people had joined us, the state would have formulated its response accordingly. The main blame lies in our inability to read India's conditions accurately.

Baji Rao: It's not just in the last two years; we were unable to extend party activities to the rest of the country. We are an underground group; we created a structure here [Dandakaranya], but we could not do so elsewhere. The government is using its power to make policies, but we could not explain to people their positive and negative sides. We also couldn't reach the educated sections. There has been a change in production patterns due to mechanisation, reflected in the way people eat and dress. We couldn't identify with it. The party made a mistake in that assessment.

Q. How did the Maoists perceive the intensified operations by the forces?

Rupesh: We agree that operations by security forces intensified, but we don't agree that the movement weakened because of these in the past two years. Operations have been going on for a long time, and we view the state the same way—whether it is the Congress or the BJP.

Q. When the Union home minister announced March 31, 2026, as the deadline for ending the movement, what was your reaction?

"INSTEAD OF BOYCOTTING POLLS, WE SHOULD HAVE LEVERAGED THEM. OUR BOYCOTT BECAME ANOTHER REASON FOR OUR ALIENATION FROM THE PEOPLE"

Baji Rao: We have not come out because of the deadline. We had failed to create a roadmap and strategy...we should have done these 10, 15 or even 20 years ago, and then followed it.

Q. How do you see the future of the movement?

Rupesh: There are limits to what I can say here. The government has set a deadline to control armed Maoists, but the country's problems persist. If the government doesn't address these issues, doesn't make appropriate policies or implement them, the agitation will continue in some form or the other. Whether the present Maoist leadership exists or not is not important. We can't stop it or continue it.

Q. What is your future plan?

Baji Rao: The situation on the ground has changed, which means the armed struggle cannot be extended and has to stop. There are many problems in the country, and if they have to be addressed, people have to connect with us. People can rise at any time. We have to organise them and raise awareness.

Q. What are your views about electoral politics?

Rupesh: My personal view is that instead of boycotting polls, we should have leveraged them. The boycott became another reason for our alienation from the people. Even if we couldn't get our candidates elected, we should have at least made our stand on the candidates clear. If need be, we could have entered politics.